

Guide 49 — Dental Assistant

Controlled English working master — Version 2.0

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What this work is

Dental assistants support dentists and dental teams with patient preparation, chairside assistance, instrument and room preparation, infection-prevention tasks, records, scheduling, supplies, and other clinical or administrative work permitted by the applicable jurisdiction and workplace.

In the United States, O*NET classifies Dental Assistants as **31-9091.00** and describes the occupation as performing limited clinical duties under the direction of a dentist. A job title alone does not determine legal scope. State dental-practice law, dental-board rules, education, radiography or expanded-function requirements, credential status, dentist delegation and supervision, and employer policy can all change what a dental assistant may perform.

This guide is for career exploration and preparation. It is not dental, medical, legal, licensing, immigration, or financial advice. Before enrolling in a program, paying for an exam, exposing radiographs, or performing an intra-oral or other regulated task, verify the current requirements where you intend to train and work.

What you may do

Depending on jurisdiction, employer, education, credential status, delegation, and supervision, duties may include:

- greeting patients and preparing them for treatment;
- preparing treatment rooms, trays, materials, instruments, and equipment;
- assisting a dentist chairside during examinations and procedures;
- passing instruments and maintaining an organized treatment field;
- cleaning, packaging, sterilizing, storing, and tracking instruments according to approved procedures;
- following hand-hygiene, PPE, sharps, exposure-control, environmental-cleaning, and waste procedures;
- recording information in approved patient records under workplace rules;
- scheduling appointments and coordinating routine follow-up;
- maintaining inventory and ordering approved supplies;
- processing routine insurance, billing, or administrative information;
- providing approved oral-hygiene or post-visit information within the worker's authorized role; and
- escalating clinical, safety, privacy, equipment, infection-control, or emergency concerns to the appropriate professional.

Some jurisdictions permit appropriately trained dental assistants to expose dental radiographs or perform specified intra-oral or expanded functions. **Do not assume that a general dental-assisting course, national credential, employer request, or past experience automatically authorizes a task.** Verify the exact legal and workplace requirements first.

What this job does not authorize by itself

A Dental Assistant title, diploma, certificate, registration, or national exam does not by itself make a person a dentist, dental hygienist, dental therapist, dental technologist, dental laboratory technician, physician, nurse, or other independently licensed clinician.

Unless separately licensed and legally authorized, do not independently:

- diagnose dental or oral disease;
- interpret radiographs for diagnosis or treatment decisions;
- prescribe or change medications;
- determine or change a treatment plan;
- perform irreversible procedures reserved to another professional;
- administer anesthetic or other restricted treatment unless the exact jurisdiction expressly authorizes it and all training, credential, supervision, and employer requirements are met;
- represent yourself as holding a license or professional title you do not possess; or
- substitute AI output, a training certificate, or an employer request for the legally required dentist judgment or supervision.

If a patient appears medically or dentally unstable, has an unexpected reaction, or reports a serious symptom, follow the office's emergency and escalation procedure rather than acting beyond your role.

State and jurisdiction rules come first

Dental assisting is strongly jurisdiction-dependent. In the United States, the Bureau of Labor Statistics states that **each state regulates the scope of practice for dental assistants.** Requirements can differ for entry-level work, radiography, coronal polishing, sealants, impressions, topical agents, expanded functions, registration, certification, and supervision.

Use the legally controlling state dental board, dental practice act, and administrative rules as the primary source. DANB provides a useful state-requirements locator, but a national credential or DANB publication does not replace state law or automatically grant the same scope in every state.

State-requirements locator: <https://www.danb.org/state-requirements/state-publications-and-services>

Dental radiography requires specific verification

O*NET includes exposing dental diagnostic x-rays among dental-assistant task examples, but this is not a nationwide authorization. Before operating radiographic equipment or positioning a patient for an exposure, verify:

- whether the state, province, or country permits a dental assistant to expose radiographs;
- required education, examination, registration, permit, or credential;
- supervision requirements;
- equipment and radiation-safety training;
- employer competency validation; and
- current renewal or continuing-education rules, if any.

Do not independently interpret a radiograph for diagnosis. Follow the dentist's approved workflow for image acquisition, quality concerns, retakes, documentation, and clinical interpretation.

Infection prevention and instrument reprocessing

Dental assistants can have substantial responsibility for infection prevention. CDC guidance for dental health care personnel includes Standard Precautions such as hand hygiene, appropriate PPE, respiratory hygiene, sharps safety, safe injection practices, sterile instruments and devices, and environmental cleaning and disinfection.

Instrument reprocessing is a controlled sequence, not generic housekeeping. Follow the device manufacturer's instructions and the employer's approved process for safe transport, cleaning, inspection, packaging, sterilization or high-level processing as applicable, storage, monitoring, documentation, and response to a failed cycle or compromised package.

Never skip cleaning, packaging, sterilization monitoring, PPE, or exposure controls because the office is busy. Never improvise a sterilization parameter or chemical concentration.

CDC infection-prevention summary:

<https://www.cdc.gov/dental-infection-control/hcp/summary/>

CDC Standard Precautions:

<https://www.cdc.gov/dental-infection-control/hcp/summary/standard-precautions.html>

CDC sterilization FAQ:

<https://www.cdc.gov/dental-infection-control/hcp/dental-ipc-faqs/dental-sterilization.html>

Bloodborne pathogens, sharps, and occupational exposure

Dental work can involve blood, saliva, sharps, aerosols, contaminated instruments, chemicals, and other hazards. OSHA identifies dentistry as an environment with potential occupational exposure to bloodborne pathogens. Dental-procedure saliva is treated as potentially infectious material for the Bloodborne Pathogens standard.

Follow the employer's exposure-control plan, PPE requirements, engineering and work-practice controls, sharps procedures, vaccination and training requirements, post-exposure reporting,

and medical evaluation process. Report a needlestick, cut, splash, or other exposure promptly according to policy rather than attempting to manage it privately.

OSHA dentistry: <https://www.osha.gov/dentistry>

OSHA bloodborne-pathogen worker protections: <https://www.osha.gov/bloodborne-pathogens/worker-protections>

Work environment and physical demands

Dental assistants commonly work in general or specialty dental offices, clinics, community health settings, educational clinics, public programs, and other oral-health environments. Schedules may include evenings or weekends depending on the employer.

The work can involve prolonged sitting or standing, repetitive hand movements, close visual work, computer use, instrument handling, bending and positioning around a dental chair, moving supplies, communicating with anxious patients, wearing PPE, and exposure to blood, saliva, aerosols, sharps, disinfectants, sterilization equipment, and radiographic systems.

Use safe ergonomics, approved lifting and handling methods, equipment safeguards, and workplace exposure controls. Ask for reasonable accessibility support where applicable rather than concealing a limitation that could affect safe work.

Important skills

Employers often value:

- calm and respectful patient communication;
- attention to detail;
- confidentiality and discretion;
- accurate records and scheduling;
- infection-prevention discipline;
- instrument and material organization;
- ability to follow dentist instructions and written procedures;
- situational awareness during chairside work;
- teamwork with dentists, hygienists, administrative staff, laboratories, and other professionals;
- reliable escalation when a situation exceeds authority;
- basic arithmetic and inventory skills;
- comfort with dental practice-management and imaging workflows; and
- willingness to learn employer-specific systems without overstating competence.

Bilingual ability can help many practices, but do not claim professional healthcare-interpreter qualification unless you have the required preparation. Use approved interpreter resources when precise clinical communication requires them.

United States — education and entry pathways

O*NET identifies Dental Assistants as **31-9091.00**. BLS states that entry routes vary by state. Some states require graduation from an accredited program and an examination; others have no formal education requirement for certain entry-level duties and allow on-the-job training. Many formal dental-assisting programs take about one year and award a certificate or diploma, while two-year associate programs are less common.

A practical entry sequence is:

1. Review 15–20 current local dental-assistant postings and note repeated requirements.
2. Check the state dental board's current dental-assisting levels, permitted functions, radiography rules, supervision, and credential requirements.
3. Compare public community-college, technical-school, Registered Apprenticeship, workforce-funded, employer-sponsored, and private options.
4. Verify tuition, fees, books, uniforms, PPE, instruments, CPR, background checks, immunizations, clinical placement, radiography training, exam fees, refund terms, and credential eligibility.
5. Prefer programs with supervised hands-on practice and clearly documented legal/credential alignment.
6. Apply only for duties that match your actual training and current authorization.

BLS source: <https://www.bls.gov/ooh/healthcare/dental-assistants.htm>

United States — Registered Apprenticeship

Apprenticeship.gov lists **Dental Assistant** among high-demand healthcare Registered Apprenticeship occupations. Registered Apprenticeship can combine paid employment, structured on-the-job learning, related instruction, mentorship, and progressive skill development.

Availability is sponsor- and location-dependent. A national occupational listing does not mean an apprenticeship opening exists in every community. Search current sponsors and confirm program status before relying on it as a training route.

Source: <https://www.apprenticeship.gov/apprenticeship-industries/healthcare>

United States — WIOA and lower-cost training

CareerOneStop's WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder links to state directories of approved training providers. If you may qualify for Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act services, contact the appropriate American Job Center and verify both your eligibility and the specific dental-assisting program before enrolling.

WIOA support is not automatic and should not be described as a guaranteed grant for dental-assisting education.

Source: <https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/EmploymentAndTraining/find-WIOA-training-programs.aspx>

Employer-paid training and advancement support

Ask dental employers about:

- paid onboarding and supervised chairside training;
- Registered Apprenticeship;
- tuition assistance;
- radiography or expanded-function training where legally permitted;
- DANB or other exam reimbursement when relevant;
- CPR or basic life support support;
- PPE, uniforms, or equipment;
- continuing education;
- cross-training in scheduling, treatment coordination, insurance, sterilization, or inventory; and
- advancement pathways.

If the employer pays for training but requires repayment or a minimum service period, obtain the terms in writing before accepting the funding.

United States — official income and employment outlook

O*NET's current workforce data reports **2025 BLS wage data** for Dental Assistants:

- **median hourly wage: USD \$23.11;** and
- **median annual wage: USD \$48,070.**

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook reports for May 2024:

- median annual wage: **USD \$47,300;**
- median hourly wage: **USD \$22.74;**
- lowest 10 percent: below **USD \$36,190;**
- highest 10 percent: above **USD \$61,780;**
- employment in 2024: approximately **381,900;**
- projected employment in 2034: approximately **406,300;**
- projected growth, 2024–2034: **6%;**
- projected numeric employment increase: approximately **24,400;** and
- projected average annual openings: approximately **52,900.**

The Version 2 guide uses the newer 2025 BLS wage series surfaced through O*NET as the current national wage anchor and keeps the BLS OOH May 2024 values clearly dated. National data is not a guaranteed starting wage. Pay varies by location, duties, specialty, employer, schedule, experience, credential, and permitted scope.

O*NET: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/31-9091.00>

BLS: <https://www.bls.gov/ooh/healthcare/dental-assistants.htm>

United States — current non-government market estimate

Salary.com reported a U.S. Dental Assistant salary estimate of approximately **USD \$41,739 per year / \$20 per hour** as of **August 1, 2026**, with a stated 25th–75th percentile range of approximately **USD \$37,596–\$46,260**, a 10th-percentile estimate of **USD \$33,824**, and a 90th-percentile estimate of **USD \$50,376**.

This is a **private, non-government market estimate**. It is methodologically different from BLS/O*NET data and must remain separate rather than being averaged with official statistics.

Source: <https://www.salary.com/research/salary/benchmark/dental-assistant-salary>

Canada — Dental Assistant mapping

Canada's NOC **33100** is titled **Dental assistants and dental laboratory assistants**. Because that unit group combines different work, readers exploring chairside dental assisting should focus on the dental-assistant duties and the more specific OaSIS profile **33100.01 — Dental assistants**, not import laboratory-assistant duties into the role.

The NOC distinguishes dental assistants from dental hygienists/dental therapists and from dental technologists/technicians. A U.S. Dental Assistant certificate or state permission does not automatically transfer Canadian practice authority.

NOC profile: <https://noc.esdc.gc.ca/Structure/NOCProfile?GocTemplateCulture=en-CA&code=33100&version=2021.0>

OaSIS hierarchy: <https://noc.esdc.gc.ca/OaSIS/OaSISHierarchy>

Canada — education, registration, and intra-oral duties

Government of Canada Job Bank reports that dental assistants typically require either completion of an eight-month to one-year college or other dental-assisting program, or secondary school plus on-the-job training.

Job Bank also reports that:

- registration with a regulatory body is required in all provinces except Quebec and Ontario;
- National Dental Assisting Examination Board certification is required to perform intra-oral duties in all provinces except Quebec; and
- in Quebec, dental assistants do not perform intra-oral duties under the national occupational description.

These statements are a national summary. The applicable provincial regulator and current law control. Verify current program approval, registration, examination, radiography, intra-oral, and supervision requirements before enrolling or accepting duties.

Source: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/4475/ca>

Canada — wages and student aid

Job Bank's current national wage page for Dental Assistant, NOC 33100, reports:

- low: **CAD \$21.00/hour**;
- median: **CAD \$27.00/hour**;
- high: **CAD \$35.00/hour**; and
- **72.3%** of workers in NOC 33100 receive at least one non-wage benefit.

The wage page was updated November 19, 2025 and uses a 2023–2024 reference period. Use province, territory, and local-area filters before making a relocation or training decision.

Job Bank wages: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/wages-occupation/4475/ca>

Eligible students in qualified programs at designated schools may receive Canada Student Grants and Loans through the appropriate provincial or territorial system. For the **2026–27** school year, the Canada Student Grant for Full-Time Students can provide up to **CAD \$4,200 per year / CAD \$525 per month of study**, subject to financial need and other eligibility rules. Quebec, the Northwest Territories, and Nunavut operate separate student-aid arrangements.

Do not assume that every private dental-assisting program is designated or aid-eligible. Verify the current institution and program before committing money.

Canada Student Grant:

<https://www.canada.ca/en/services/benefits/education/student-aid/grants-loans/full-time.html>

Colombia — Auxiliares de salud oral, CUOC 53292

Colombia's Ministry of Labour OCUPACOL identifies **CUOC 53292 — Auxiliares de salud oral**. Occupational titles include *auxiliar de consultorio dental*, *auxiliar de consultorio odontológico*, *auxiliar de odontología*, *auxiliar de odontología e higiene oral*, *auxiliar de salud oral*, *auxiliar higiene oral*, and *ayudante odontología*.

The profile includes preparing the dental environment and patient, assisting the dentist, sterilizing and organizing instruments, preparing materials, recording information, managing supplies, giving oral-hygiene information, assisting with impressions, and taking radiographs according to technical procedure and dentist instructions.

These profile functions are occupational descriptions, not permission for independent dental practice. The applicable health rules, training, ReTHUS registration, dentist direction, employer procedures, and any radiation-safety requirements still control.

Source: <https://ocupacol.mintrabajo.gov.co/Profile/OccupationalProfile/53292>

OCUPACOL also contains a separate **Higienistas y asistentes odontológicos** profile with broader functions. **Do not copy higher-scope diagnostic, preventive, anesthetic, extraction, or other functions from that separate profile into CUOC 53292.** Guide 49's Colombia pathway is anchored to *Auxiliares de salud oral — CUOC 53292* unless current

competent-authority evidence establishes a different scope for the learner's exact credential and setting.

Colombia — training, ReTHUS, and SENA pathway

Colombia's Decree 1409 of 2024 expressly lists **Auxiliar en Salud Oral** among auxiliary health personnel and establishes current certificate/training provisions. The decree distinguishes certificates issued within SENA/the Subsistema de Formación para el Trabajo from ETDH *Técnico Laboral por Competencias* certificates and requires holders to request the corresponding registration in **ReTHUS** through the Ministry of Health or its designated entity.

Regulatory source:

https://normograma.sena.edu.co/compilacion/docs/decreto_1409_2024.htm

SENA Resolution 2057 of July 4, 2025 records an update to the **Técnico Laboral en Salud Oral** program. The updated pathway addresses administrative and assistive oral-health functions, promotion and prevention, support to the dentist in consultation, appointment scheduling, activity recording, risk management, and patient safety.

SENA program-update source:

https://normograma.sena.edu.co/compilacion/docs/resolucion_sena_2057_2025.htm

SENA's Betowa catalog currently displays **SALUD ORAL** as a presencial, titulada technical pathway with cohort-specific offerings. Offer dates, centres, modality details, admission conditions, and cohort availability change.

Betowa: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/salud-oral>

Important Colombia duration control

Current public SENA/Colombian sources reviewed for this revision do not provide a simple, fully reconciled text-only explanation of every program-duration field after the 2024 regulatory amendment and the 2025 SENA program update. Public Betowa metadata may display a duration associated with a program or cohort while the amended regulatory framework contains general auxiliary-health certificate duration language.

Do not publish one definitive national SENA Dental Assistant/Salud Oral program duration from these sources. Before enrolling, verify the exact current Betowa cohort, training centre, approved curriculum, certificate, registration requirement, and any ReTHUS requirement. If duration is material to a decision, obtain it from the current official cohort/program record.

Colombia — sterilization and reprocessing boundaries

Colombia's Ministry of Health Resolution 914 of 2025 establishes requirements for reprocessing reusable medical devices and elements. The regulated framework includes *auxiliar de salud oral*, as applicable, among personnel who may perform reprocessing activities.

This supports strong instrument-processing preparation, but it does not authorize a worker to improvise sterilization parameters or practice independently beyond the applicable health, workplace, manufacturer, and professional rules.

Source:

https://normograma.sena.edu.co/compilacion/docs/resolucion_minsaludps_0914_2025.htm

Latin America and the Caribbean

Dental-assistant titles, vocational systems, dental-practice laws, radiography rules, delegated functions, credentials, and scopes differ across the region. A title such as *asistente dental*, *auxiliar de odontología*, *auxiliar de salud oral*, *asistente odontológico*, or similar wording does not establish the same legal scope from country to country.

Use OIT/Cinterfor as a regional vocational-training locator, then verify the current national health, education, radiation-safety, and dental-profession authorities before paying for training or performing regulated duties.

OIT/Cinterfor: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/>

Institutional network: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/red-institucional>

A U.S., Canadian, Colombian, or other national credential does not automatically transfer legal scope across borders.

Patient privacy and dental records

Dental offices handle sensitive health, insurance, billing, contact, image, and radiographic information. In U.S. covered entities, the HIPAA Privacy Rule protects individually identifiable protected health information, and the HIPAA Security Rule establishes administrative, physical, and technical safeguards for electronic protected health information.

HHS Privacy Rule: <https://www.hhs.gov/hipaa/for-professionals/privacy/index.html>

HHS Security Rule: <https://www.hhs.gov/hipaa/for-professionals/security/index.html>

Follow the law and employer policy that applies to your workplace. Access only records needed for authorized work. Do not open a patient chart out of curiosity. Do not photograph screens or radiographs with a personal device unless explicitly authorized within a compliant workflow. Report misdirected records, suspicious access, lost devices, phishing, or other privacy/security events promptly.

Using AI responsibly in dental assisting

AI can help with low-risk activities such as:

- explaining general dental terminology for study;
- generating fictional charting or scheduling exercises;
- creating practice interview questions;
- organizing a non-sensitive study plan;
- drafting generic patient-service language for later employer review; or

- rehearsing how to escalate a fictional workplace scenario.

AI must **not** replace dentist judgment, radiographic interpretation, diagnosis, treatment planning, emergency decisions, medication instructions, infection-control procedures, sterilizer manufacturer instructions, or approved patient records.

Never paste patient names, birth dates, contact information, dental images, radiographs, histories, diagnoses, insurance identifiers, appointment details, payment data, or other protected/confidential information into a public or unauthorized AI service.

Any patient-facing text generated with AI must be checked against approved employer and clinical sources before use. If an AI answer conflicts with a dentist's order, current procedure, manufacturer instruction, regulator, or approved reference, stop and escalate.

Cybersecurity basics for a dental office

Follow employer rules for:

- unique accounts and multifactor authentication;
- password and credential protection;
- screen locking;
- approved practice-management and imaging-system access;
- minimum-necessary patient-data access;
- secure email, messaging, and file transfer;
- phishing and suspicious attachments;
- verification of unusual payment, bank, payroll, insurance, portal, or account-change requests;
- backups and approved storage;
- printing and secure disposal;
- portable devices and removable media;
- incident and privacy-event reporting; and
- personal devices, cloud storage, transcription tools, and AI services.

Never disable a security safeguard for convenience or share a login because a colleague is busy.

Free-first learning strategy

Before paying a private school:

1. Read 15–20 current local dental-assistant job postings.
2. Check the legal dental-assisting levels and radiography/expanded-function requirements in the target jurisdiction.
3. Learn basic dental terminology, tooth numbering, infection-prevention concepts, professional communication, privacy, and workplace safety from reputable sources.
4. Ask public colleges, technical schools, workforce centres, dental employers, community clinics, and apprenticeship sponsors about lower-cost or funded options.
5. Compare at least three programs using **total** cost, not advertised tuition alone.

6. Verify clinical practice, radiography preparation, CPR, materials, uniforms, background checks, immunizations, exam eligibility, placement, refund terms, and financing.
7. Pay for a private credential only after confirming that it aligns with current law and target employers.

Free online learning can strengthen knowledge but does not replace supervised hands-on training for a regulated or clinical skill.

A practical 12-week start plan

Weeks 1–2: Review local postings and the current regulator/dental-board rules. List repeated education, radiography, CPR, infection-control, software, language, and experience requirements.

Weeks 3–4: Study dental terminology, tooth surfaces/numbering, basic materials vocabulary, privacy, professional communication, and infection-prevention concepts without using real patient data.

Weeks 5–6: Compare public, apprenticeship, workforce-funded, employer-sponsored, and private pathways. Verify complete cost and legal/credential alignment.

Weeks 7–8: Complete only supervised skills practice through an authorized program or employer. Focus on chairside workflow, instrument handling, PPE, sharps safety, environmental cleaning, sterilization/reprocessing, documentation, and escalation.

Weeks 9–10: Build an accurate résumé and skills inventory. Separate classroom practice, simulation, observation, externship experience, and independent paid work instead of blending them.

Weeks 11–12: Apply to roles matching your verified preparation. Prepare examples showing patient respect, accuracy, infection-control discipline, confidentiality, teamwork, and safe escalation.

Building experience without overstating scope

Relevant transferable experience can include:

- healthcare or dental reception;
- customer service in regulated environments;
- appointment scheduling;
- insurance or billing support;
- inventory and supply work;
- sterilization/reprocessing training under supervision;
- community oral-health outreach;
- supervised externships;
- Registered Apprenticeship; and
- documented employer training.

Describe exactly what you did. Do not list a procedure as independent competence because you observed it, practiced it once in a lab, or assisted while another professional performed it.

Career progression

With additional education, credentials, experience, and jurisdiction-specific authorization, possible directions may include senior dental assistant, lead dental assistant, expanded-function dental assistant where recognized, orthodontic or oral-surgery assisting, treatment coordination, dental office administration, community oral-health support, sterilization/infection-prevention coordination, or other dental-support roles.

Dental hygienist, dental therapist, dental technologist, laboratory technician, and dentist are separate occupations with their own education and regulatory requirements. Do not present ordinary Dental Assistant experience as automatically qualifying a person for those scopes.

Accessibility and accommodations

Dental assisting can require fine motor control, close visual work, hearing and communication, prolonged posture, mobility around treatment equipment, PPE use, and rapid response to clinical instructions. A disability does not automatically rule out the occupation, but safe performance of essential functions matters.

When relevant, ask training providers and employers about accessible classrooms, clinical spaces, adaptive technology, communication support, ergonomic equipment, modified scheduling, or other reasonable accommodations available under applicable law. Do not rely on a school marketing statement as a guarantee that every clinical placement or employer can support every accommodation.

Avoid scams and weak training programs

Be cautious when a school, recruiter, credential seller, or employer:

- guarantees employment or a specific salary;
- says one certificate authorizes every dental task everywhere;
- promises radiography or expanded-function authority without explaining current jurisdiction requirements;
- claims a short generic online course replaces supervised hands-on training for clinical skills;
- hides tuition, financing, refund, or clinical-placement terms;
- cannot explain exam eligibility or regulatory alignment;
- pressures you to enroll immediately;
- promises a government license that does not exist for the program;
- asks you to pay for a job offer with gift cards, cryptocurrency, or unusual transfers; or
- requests sensitive identity, banking, or patient information before you have verified the organization.

Verify the school, credential, regulator, employer, and job independently before paying or sharing sensitive information.

When to pause before spending money

Pause enrollment when:

- you have not checked the current legal scope and radiography rules where you plan to work;
- target employers do not request the credential being sold;
- the program will not explain supervised clinical practice;
- exam or registration eligibility is unclear;
- total cost and refund terms are not disclosed;
- a public, apprenticeship, workforce-funded, student-aid-supported, or employer-paid route may cover the same preparation;
- the school makes cross-border credential-transfer promises without regulator evidence; or
- financing would create debt you cannot comfortably repay.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- U.S. Department of Labor O*NET OnLine — Dental Assistants, 31-9091.00: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/details/31-9091.00>
- O*NET summary / 2025 BLS national wage data — Dental Assistants: <https://www.onetonline.org/link/summary/31-9091.00>
- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Occupational Outlook Handbook, Dental Assistants: <https://www.bls.gov/ooh/healthcare/dental-assistants.htm>
- Apprenticeship.gov — Healthcare Registered Apprenticeship: <https://www.apprenticeship.gov/apprenticeship-industries/healthcare>
- CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder: <https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/EmploymentAndTraining/find-WIOA-training-programs.aspx>
- CDC — Summary of Infection Prevention Practices in Dental Settings: <https://www.cdc.gov/dental-infection-control/hcp/summary/>
- CDC — Standard Precautions in Dental Settings: <https://www.cdc.gov/dental-infection-control/hcp/summary/standard-precautions.html>
- CDC — Dental sterilization and monitoring FAQ: <https://www.cdc.gov/dental-infection-control/hcp/dental-ipc-faqs/dental-sterilization.html>
- OSHA — Dentistry: <https://www.osha.gov/dentistry>
- OSHA — Bloodborne Pathogens worker protections: <https://www.osha.gov/bloodborne-pathogens/worker-protections>
- HHS — HIPAA Privacy Rule: <https://www.hhs.gov/hipaa/for-professionals/privacy/index.html>
- HHS — HIPAA Security Rule: <https://www.hhs.gov/hipaa/for-professionals/security/index.html>

- Government of Canada NOC 33100 — Dental assistants and dental laboratory assistants: <https://noc.esdc.gc.ca/Structure/NOCProfile?GocTemplateCulture=en-CA&code=33100&version=2021.0>
- Government of Canada OaSIS hierarchy: <https://noc.esdc.gc.ca/OaSIS/OaSISHierarchy>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Dental Assistant requirements: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/4475/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Dental Assistant wages: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/wages-occupation/4475/ca>
- Government of Canada — Canada Student Grant for Full-Time Students: <https://www.canada.ca/en/services/benefits/education/student-aid/grants-loans/full-time.html>
- Colombia Ministerio del Trabajo OCUPACOL — CUOC 53292 Auxiliares de salud oral: <https://ocupacol.mintrabajo.gov.co/Profile/OccupationalProfile/53292>
- SENA Normograma — Decreto 1409 de 2024: https://normograma.sena.edu.co/compilacion/docs/decreto_1409_2024.htm
- SENA Normograma — Resolución SENA 2057 de 2025, actualización del programa Técnico Laboral en Salud Oral: https://normograma.sena.edu.co/compilacion/docs/resolucion_sena_2057_2025.htm
- SENA Betowa — Salud Oral: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/oferta/salud-oral>
- SENA Normograma — Resolución Minsalud 914 de 2025, reprocesamiento de dispositivos médicos reutilizables: https://normograma.sena.edu.co/compilacion/docs/resolucion_minsaludps_0914_2025.htm
- OIT/Cinterfor regional vocational-training locator: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/>
- OIT/Cinterfor institutional network: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/red-institucional>

Specialized state-requirements locator:

- Dental Assisting National Board — state publications and services: <https://www.danb.org/state-requirements/state-publications-and-services>

Supplementary non-government salary source:

- Salary.com — Dental Assistant salary, August 1, 2026: <https://www.salary.com/research/salary/benchmark/dental-assistant-salary>

Source and review note

This guide uses current-source research recorded on August 19, 2026. Occupation titles, state/provincial/national scope rules, radiography permissions, credentials, training requirements, ReTHUS processes, program availability, wages, funding, and employer expectations can change. Recheck current official sources and local job postings before making an education or employment decision.

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